

A BROKEN STRUCTURE, NOT A BAD NIGHT, COST INDIA ITS ASIAN DREAM

India's failure to qualify for the AFC Asian Cup exposes **deep issues** — from ISL limbo to federation drift. Can Khalid Jamil steady the sinking ship?

Chaotic reality: A burst of effort in a campaign defined by drift — India's fight lacked direction when it mattered most. PICS: AIFF

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Two head coaches, a national league in limbo, players skipping national camps, and a federation seemingly adrift — the last eight months in Indian football have culminated in failure to qualify for the AFC Asian Cup for the first time since 2019.

On paper, India was expected to top Group C of the qualifiers, which included lower-ranked sides Hong Kong, Singapore, and Bangladesh. Yet, after four rounds, the Blue Tigers sit bottom of the table, winless, with just two goals to show.

If last year's results were bad, this year's have been worse when it

mattered most. The defeat to Singapore in Goa was another dismal night — only 10% of the 19,000-seater stadium was occupied. Unless the people in charge act decisively, Indian football will continue its quiet fade into irrelevance.

Somewhere in the same State, former head coach Manolo Marquez might have watched with a sense of relief that he was no longer the face of this failure.

Managing the national team was once a dream for Marquez, but the job quickly soured. "When you see that all the teams don't play by the same rules [naturalisation process], you feel like this isn't the place for you," he conceded in an interview with Marca.

Three days before the away game in Hong Kong in June, the players already knew it would be the Spaniard's last match. India went on to lose to Hong Kong for the first time in 15 years. Marquez pointed fingers, including at himself, before resigning in July, less than a year into the role.

The Federation's next move felt like a last-ditch appointment. Khalid Jamil ticked many boxes: he communicates well with players, has turned underdogs into contenders, and, crucially, tends to make the most of limited resources without complaint. Even after the loss to Singapore, Jamil refused to single out individuals.

Unlike his predecessors — Igor Stimac and Marquez — Jamil is